Philosophy Lectures · outside the curriculum; it falls within History of Philosophy (2nd year) and Philosophy (1st year) · If God is dead, what is left? · Class 3 of 8 · With Javier

Dictating to oneself

Class video: https://youtu.be/5_jlpCRE0xI
This sheet online: https://gincollab.github.io/aula/en/conf-filosofia/t01-c3/
The code leads to the video.

In a nutshell

It is a **lecture, not a class**: about twenty minutes for listening and thinking, with no exercises, no countdowns and no questions to take home. Javier speaks from the school assembly hall. It is the third in a series of eight, "If God is dead, what is left?", and it stands on its own.

The message, what listeners take away for their own lives: *if no one dictates to you what has value, don't settle for what is comfortable: create for yourself what has value, and live in such a way that you would want to live it again, without trampling on anyone.* It is Nietzsche in a positive key: if there is no one to dictate anything to me, I am the one who dictates it to myself. And it is not "anything goes": it is the opposite.

It is Javier's reading, and he says so. At the start he tells us what he thinks, "which isn't dogma". He reads the overman as self-overcoming, and the will to power, above all, as power over oneself; he says that this is his reading, and that the will to power is "sometimes" also wanting to command. And he says where he parts ways with Nietzsche.

The journey. The three questions of lecture 1 (what is true, what is right and what is wrong, what we live for) arrive as lecture 2 left them: reason, the law I give myself, and God, as hope. Nietzsche finds that hope empty, and two answers change before the viewer's eyes:

- **The last man.** A life without upsets, which at first sight has nothing wrong with it. Zarathustra comes down from the mountain to the market place, proclaims the overman, and they laugh at him. So he describes the most despicable thing, the last man: the one who no longer shoots "the arrow of his longing" beyond himself, "the one who can no longer despise himself". He is no layabout: he works, because work entertains him, and he "honours health"; he has his little pleasure for the day and for the night, and he "has invented happiness". What is despicable is not that his life is

comfortable: it is that he no longer wants anything higher. The crowd clamours for that last man. Then come the map of the series, the chair and its three questions, lecture 2 in a sentence and the thesis.

- **The camel, the lion and the child.** The three metamorphoses: the camel carries the heaviest load; the lion says "I will" to the dragon "Thou shalt", on whose scales gleam thousand-year-old values, and wins freedom, but cannot create; the child says "a sacred yes", without reservation: value is no longer given by God, it is given by that yes, and that is why the child creates.
- **To value is to create.** The dragon "Thou shalt" is the age-old duty, and Javier ties it to Kant's; Nietzsche answers Kant: "that each one invent his own virtue, his own categorical imperative" (*The Antichrist*, § 11). Values do not fall from the sky: human beings gave themselves their good and evil, and they can be remade (the revaluation, or transvaluation, of all values). Slave morality says no to what is different; master morality says yes to itself (*On the Genealogy of Morality*, I, 10). The second question passes to "my virtue, invented by me". And a danger, announced.
- **The overman.** "Man is something that shall be overcome": the rope over the abyss and the tightrope walker who falls ("you have made danger your calling"). Three readings that miss it: a new species (Zarathustra compares it to the step from ape to man, but it is an image, and Nietzsche complained of being accused of Darwinism), a race, and the best version of yourself, which is just polishing what you already are. What it is: the meaning of the earth. The third question passes to "this life, this earth", with the motto "dead are all the gods: now we want the overman to live"; the believer's answer comes in lecture 7. The will to power (what is alive does not just want to last, it wants to grow; and life, "that which must always overcome itself") and "become who you are", with Pindar in full.
- **What they did with him.** His sister Elisabeth, married to an antisemitic agitator; what Nietzsche wrote to her; his madness, the book he did not write (*The Will to Power*) and the Nazis, who picked out the sentences that suited them; one of their ideologues read the overman as the German people. His overman is neither a race nor a State: "there, where the State ends", says Zarathustra, are "the bridges of the overman". But Javier does not sell "a sugar-coated Nietzsche": there are pages against compassion, against equality and against women, and he ties inequality to his overman; with pages like these, he made it easy for whoever wanted to use him. Javier says where he parts ways: he keeps the overman who overcomes himself; **other people exist**, and dictating to yourself is not dictating to others.
- **The greatest weight.** The idea, by a rock at Lake Silvaplana, in August 1881. The demon of *The Gay Science* (§ 341) and the eternal recurrence. Nietzsche came to believe it literally ("you will live again in any case!"); for Javier, what matters is the question, and the task from the same notebook: "to live in such a way that you must wish to live again". Two tests: Kant multiplies what you do by everyone; Nietzsche, by eternity. And *amor fati*, which is not resignation: "thus I shall be one of those who make things beautiful".
- **What is left?** The three questions, changed (the first, the one about truth, Nietzsche shook too, and it is left out); either you take the chair, or someone else will; Zarathustra does not want followers. The message, and the farewell: "if no one dictates to you what has value, dictate it to yourself. And I add: without trampling on anyone".

For readers outside Spain: the Bachillerato is the last two years of secondary school (ages 16–18); Philosophy is compulsory in the first year for every track, and History of Philosophy in the second. On this

sheet, "1st year" and "2nd year" (1.º and 2.º in Spanish) are those two years. Royal Decree 243/2022 sets the minimum curriculum of the Bachillerato for the whole of Spain; the Philosophy Lectures are one of the channel's series and sit outside it. The video is in Spanish, with English subtitles. On this sheet the quotations are given in our own English translation, made from Nietzsche's German (and, for Pindar, from the Greek). A *comentario de texto*, or text commentary, is the classic Spanish classroom exercise of explaining a philosophical passage in writing.

Where it falls in the curriculum

The Lectures sit outside the curriculum: they neither follow the syllabus nor replace it. But this one falls squarely within it (Spain's Royal Decree 243/2022, annex II; the decree's wording, in our translation of the official Spanish text):

Subject and block	What the decree says	What the lecture adds
History of Philosophy, 2nd year, block C	"The deconstruction of the Western tradition in Friedrich Nietzsche and the postmodern legacy".	The moral and religious side: the last man and the nihilism of comfort; the three metamorphoses; the critique of Kant's duty (*The Antichrist*, § 11); the revaluation, and master and slave morality; the overman, the will to power and the eternal recurrence, with their texts; the Nazi appropriation, taken apart with them. The critique of truth and of metaphysics is left for another occasion: the lecture says so in a sentence
Philosophy, 1st year, block C	"The main answers to the ethical problem: consequentialist ethics, ethics of duty and virtue ethics. Nietzsche's amoral morality".	Kant's test (what if everyone did it?) set against Nietzsche's (what if you had to do it forever?); values as creation; and the limit Javier sets: other people

How the lecture is built

Video chapters

Minute	Chapter
0:00	The last man
3:36	The camel, the lion and the child
5:40	To value is to create
7:28	The overman
11:15	What they did with him
14:18	The greatest weight
17:21	What is left?

- **Seven chapters**, each with something that moves: the ordinary person and their little pleasures, Zarathustra coming down from the mountain to the market place, the row of identical people, the engravings of the camel, the lion and the dragon (from Edward Topsell's bestiary, 1658) and the one of the child with a hoop (from Jacob Abbott's *Harper's Story Books*, 1854), the dragon with a "Thou shalt" that lights up on every scale, the tablet of values that falls from the sky and is crossed out, the two towers with the rope and the tightrope walker who falls, the Earth turning, the arrow that comes back to whoever shoots it, the real rock by the lake, the day that comes back again and again, receding into the distance, Kant's crowd set against Nietzsche's eternity, and the chair with its candle, and the child beside it.
- **The visual thread is the three cards** of lecture 1: "what is right" goes from "the law I give myself" to "my virtue, invented by me"; "what we live for", from "God, as hope" to "this life, this earth".
- **Eight pauses**, without warning and without a countdown:
- If you were offered a life like that, comfortable and without questions, would you accept it?
- And you, right now, are you more camel, lion or child?
- What were you handed as good that you have never weighed again?
- And you, what would you have to overcome to become who you are?
- If each of us invents our own values, what stops someone from inventing the value of crushing you?
- If you had to live your life just the same, over and over again, forever, what would you change?
- The series' question: if God is dead, what is left?
- And you, would you want to live today over again?
- **Each quotation, with its work** on screen. Javier reads them; Nietzsche is given no voice. The translations into Spanish are our own and literal, checked against the digital critical edition (eKGWB). What Javier says in his own words goes on the board in chalk, not as a quotation.

Using it in class, if you wish

The lecture sets no task. If teachers want to use it, here are three ways, from least to most time:

- **Reading aloud.** "On the Three Metamorphoses" takes five minutes to read and is on the student worksheet in full. After the lecture, students recognise the dragon and can ask themselves what scales their own one has.
- **With 1st-year students, fifteen minutes of dialogue.** Three questions, with no single answer:
- What is wrong with the last man's life, if no one suffers? What is it missing?
- How are Kant's test (what if everyone did it?) and Nietzsche's (what if you had to do it forever?) alike, and how do they differ? What action would pass one and not the other?
- If each of us invents our own values, what stops someone from inventing the value of crushing another person? What would Kant answer, what does Javier answer, and what would you answer?
- **With 2nd-year students, a text commentary.** *The Gay Science*, § 341, in full (it is on the student worksheet, with its German; in English, also in Thomas Common's public-domain translation, *The Joyful Wisdom*, at Project Gutenberg). The lecture serves as an introduction and does not do the commentary for them: it leaves out the cosmological reading of the eternal recurrence, the posthumous fragments on it and the link with the *amor fati* of *Ecce Homo*.

Misreadings the lecture takes apart

What is often said	What the text says
The last man is a couch potato	"One still works, for work is an entertainment", and "one honours health" (*Zarathustra*, Prologue, 5). He is "the one who can no longer despise himself"
The overman is the next step in evolution	Zarathustra makes the comparison ("What is the ape to man?", Prologue, 3), but it is an image: Nietzsche complains that, because of that word, he was accused of Darwinism (*Ecce Homo*, "Why I Write Such Good Books", 1)
The will to power is wanting to rule over others	Sometimes it is ("even in the will of the one who serves I found the will to be master"), but what is alive, above all, wants to grow, and life is "that which must always overcome itself" (*Zarathustra*, II, "On Self-Overcoming")

What is often said	What the text says
The eternal recurrence is only a thought experiment	Nietzsche came to think of it as literal ("you will live again in any case!", notebook of 1881). Reading it as a practical test is one reading, widespread today, which Javier makes his own
The overman is the best version of you	What can be loved in man is that he is "a passing-over and a going-under", a bridge and not a goal (Prologue, 4)
The Will to Power is a book by Nietzsche	His sister and Peter Gast put it together from notes in his notebooks (1901 and 1906); he had abandoned the project
Elisabeth married a Nazi	Bernhard Förster, an antisemitic agitator, died in 1889, thirty years before the Nazi party existed
Amor fati is a Stoic idea	The formula is Nietzsche's (*The Gay Science*, § 276; *Ecce Homo*, "Why I Am So Clever", 10)
The dragon says "all values have already been created"	"All value has already been created" (*Aller Werth ward schon geschaffen*), and on its scales gleam "thousand-year-old values"
The 1881 sheet says "6000 feet beyond man and time"	That is how *Ecce Homo* remembers it, in 1888. The sheet says "6000 feet above the sea and much higher above all human things" (NF-1881,11[141])

Going further: what the lecture doesn't say aloud

- **The Nazi ideologue** who read the overman as the German people was Alfred Baeumler, in his *Nietzsche, der Philosoph und Politiker* (1931): M. Whyte, "Nietzsche and the Nazis", *Wilson Quarterly*, 2008. And in *On the Genealogy of Morality* (I, 7), Nietzsche attributes the "slave revolt in morality" to the Jews: if the passage on masters and slaves is read, it should be read with its context and its critique.
- **More of the last man**: "one must still have chaos within oneself to be able to give birth to a dancing star"; and "No shepherd and one herd!", which turns John 10:16 on its head.
- **More of Zarathustra to his disciples**: "one repays a teacher badly if one always remains only the pupil".
- **Antisemitism**: in *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887, III, 26) he writes that he does not like "these latest speculators in idealism, the antisemites" either; and to Theodor Fritsch, an antisemitic publisher, on 29 March 1887: "what do you think I feel when the name Zarathustra is taken into the

mouths of antisemites?". But, as the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* points out, Nietzsche also uses anti-Jewish stereotypes. The honest thing is to say both. The most quoted letter against his sister (the one with the "antisemitic chief" and the "greatest stupidities") is not in the critical edition: it comes from an edition of letters prepared by Elisabeth herself.

- **The hard pages**, in full: compassion (*The Antichrist*, 2 and 7), equality (*Zarathustra* II, "On the Tarantulas"; *Beyond Good and Evil*, 257) and women (*Zarathustra* I, "On Little Old and Young Women"; *Beyond Good and Evil*, 231–239).
- **Hitler and the archive**: he met Elisabeth in Weimar on 30 January 1932, visited the Nietzsche Archive several times between 1932 and 1935, and was guest of honour at her funeral, on 11 November 1935. There is no record that he read Nietzsche seriously (Klassik Stiftung Weimar, 2024).

Open resources

- Nietzsche, works, notebooks and letters in German: the digital critical edition (eKGWB), freely accessible: http://www.nietzschesource.org/#eKGWB
- *Also sprach Zarathustra*, in German, on Project Gutenberg: https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/7205 ; *Ecce homo*: https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/7202
- Nietzsche in English, in public-domain translations on Project Gutenberg: *Thus Spake Zarathustra*, tr. Thomas Common: https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1998 ; *The Joyful Wisdom* (*The Gay Science*), tr. Thomas Common: https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/52881 ; *The Genealogy of Morals*, tr. Horace B. Samuel: https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/52319 ; *The Antichrist*, tr. H. L. Mencken: https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/19322 ; *Ecce Homo*, tr. Anthony M. Ludovici: https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/52190
- Klassik Stiftung Weimar, the Nietzsche Archive: https://www.klassik-stiftung.de/nietzsche-archiv/
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy: "Friedrich Nietzsche", https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/nietzsche/ ; "Nietzsche's Life and Works", https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/nietzsche-life-works/ ; "Nietzsche's Moral and Political Philosophy", https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/nietzsche-moral-political/
- Pindar, *Pythian Odes* II, in Greek (Perseus): https://www.perseus.tufts.edu/hopper/text?doc=Perseus%3Atext%3A1999.01.0161%3Abook%3DP.%3Apoem%3D2 ; in English, *The Extant Odes of Pindar*, tr. Ernest Myers (Project Gutenberg): https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/10717

Sources

- Nietzsche, *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1883–1885): Prologue, 3 to 6; I, "On the Three Metamorphoses", "On the Thousand and One Goals", "On the New Idol", "On the Bestowing Virtue", 3; II, "On Self-Overcoming", "On the Tarantulas". *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (1882), § 270, 276 and 341. *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887), I, 10. *Der Antichrist* (written in 1888, published in 1895), § 11. *Ecce homo* (written in 1888, published in 1908), "Why I Write Such Good Books", 1, and "Thus Spoke

Zarathustra", 1. Notebooks of 1881, NF-1881,11[141] and 11[163]. Draft of a letter to Elisabeth, late December 1887 (BVN-1887,968). All in the eKGWB.

- Pindar, *Pythian Odes* II, 72.
- Klassik Stiftung Weimar (the Nietzsche Archive and its 2024 brochure on the Archive and National Socialism); *Neue Deutsche Biographie*, "Förster-Nietzsche, Elisabeth"; *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.
- The checks, quotation by quotation, with the original and the translation (in Spanish): `clases/conf-filosofia-t01-c3/verificacion-diseno.md` (31 points) and `revision-independiente.md`.
- The Nazi appropriation: *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, "Nietzsche's Life and Works"; Britannica; M. Whyte, "Nietzsche and the Nazis", *Wilson Quarterly* (2008); Klassik Stiftung Weimar, "Netzwerk Förster-Nietzsche – Adolf Hitler".

About this lecture

Javier is an illustrated character and his voice is synthetic, as the video's notice says. The script is written by an AI (Claude, by Anthropic) and reviewed by a person. Every fact and every quotation has been checked in the original source or in two sources. This English version was translated by the same AI and reviewed by a person. This sheet is licensed under CC BY 4.0.

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